The Boy in the Striped Pajamas

By John Boyne

SHMUEL: **(Pg 126)** All I know is this. Before we came here I lived with my mother and father and my brother Josef in a small flat above the store where Papa makes his watches. Every morning while we went to school, Papa mended the watches that people brought to him and made new ones too.

INTRODUCTION

This is the story of an event seared into the fabric of history. It is a fable told through the voice of a child . . . but it is not for children. The year is 1943. Bruno is 9-years-old and is quite unaware of a place called Auschwitz and the fate of the Jews where were sent there. All he knows is that his father is a soldier. Shmeul is also 9, but lives on the other side of the fence. They form a friendship that crosses dangerous boundaries and can only end in tragedy. And somehow, events are all the more tragic when narrated by those who do not understand. The Boy in the Striped Pajamas by John Boyne

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SHMUEL: **(Pg 126-128)** And then one day things started to change. I came home from school and my mother was making armbands for us and drawing a star on each one. Like this *(Draws a Star of David in the air).* And every time we left the house, she told us we had to wear one of these armbands.

BRUNO: My father wears one too . . . on his uniform. It's very nice. It's bright red with a black-and-white design on it. *(Draws a swastika in the air)*

SCHMUEL: Yes, but they're different, aren't they?

BRUNO: No one's ever given me an armband.

SHMUEL: But I never asked to wear one.

BRUNO: All the same, I think I'd quite like one. I don't know which one I'd prefer though, your one or Father's.

SCHMUEL: We wore the armbands for a few months, and then things changed again. I came home one day and Mama said we couldn't live in our house anymore.

BRUNO: That happened to me too! The Fury came for dinner, you see, and the next thing I knew we moved

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here. And I ***hate*** it here. Did he come to your house and do the same thing?

SCHMUEL: No, but when we were told we couldn't live in our house, we had to move to a different part of Cracow, where the soldiers built a big wall and my mother and father and my brother and I all had to live in one room.

BRUNO: All of you? In one room?

SCHMUEL: And not just us. There was another family there and the mother and father were always fighting with each other and one of the sons was bigger than me and he hit me even when I did nothing wrong.

BRUNO: You can't have all lived in the one room. That doesn't make any sense.

SCHMUEL: All of us. Eleven in total. **(Pg 129-132)** Then one day the soldiers all came with huge trucks and everyone was told to leave the houses. Lots of people didn't want to and they hid, but in the end I think they caught everyone. And the trucks took us to a train and a train . . . . and the train was horrible.

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There were too many of us in the carriages for one thing. And there was no air to breathe. And it smelled awful.

BRUNO: That's because you all crowded onto one train. When we came here, there was another one on the side of the platform but no one seemed to see it. That was the one we got. You should have got on it too.

SCHMUEL: I don't think we would have been allowed. We weren't able to get out of our carriage.

BRUNO: The doors are at the end.

SCHMUEL: There weren't any doors.

BRUNO: Of course there were door. They're at the end. Just past the buffet section.

SCHMUEL: There weren't any doors. If there had been, we would all have got off. When the train finally stopped, we were in a very cold place and we all had to walk here.

BRUNO: We had a car

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SCHMUEL: And Mama was taken away from us, and Papa and Josef and I were put into the huts over there and that's where we've been ever since.

BRUNO: Are there many other boys over there?

SCHMUEL: Hundreds.

BRUNO: Hundreds? That's not fair at all. There's no one to play with on this side of the fence. Not a single person.

SCHMUEL: We don't play. . . . . You don't have any food on you, do you?

BRUNO: Afraid not . . . perhaps you can come to dinner with us one evening.

SCHMUEL: Perhaps

BRUNO: Or I could come to you. Perhaps I could come and meet your friends.

SCHMUEL: You're on the wrong side of the fence though.

BRUNO: I could crawl under. *(Reaches down and lifts the wire fence off the ground)*

SCHMUEL: I have to go back.

BRUNO: Some other afternoon then.

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SCHMUEL: I'm not supposed to be here. If they catch me, I'll be in trouble.

BRUNO: **(Pg 133)** I'll come back tomorrow.

(Pg 161) For several weeks the rain was on and off and on and off and Bruno and Schmuel did not see as much of each other as they would have liked.

BRUNO: **(Pg 194-196)** I thought you weren't coming any more. I came yesterday and the day before and you weren't here.

SCHMUEL: I'm sorry. Something happened. . . . Papa. We can't find him.

BRUNO: Can't find him? That's very odd. You mean he's lost?

SCHMUEL: I suppose so. He was here on Monday and then he went on work duty with some other men and none of them have come back.

BRUNO: And hasn't he written you a letter? Or left a note to say when he'll be coming back?

SCHMUEL: No.

BRUNO: How odd. Have you looked for him?

SCHMUEL: Of course I have.

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BRUNO: And there was no sign?

SCHMUEL: None.

BRUNO: Well, that's very strange. But I think there must be a simple explanation. I could ask Father if you wanted.

SCHMUEL: I don't think that would be a good idea.

BRUNO: Why not? Father is very knowledgeable about life on that side of the fence.

SCHMUEL: I don't think the soldiers like us. Well, I know they don't like us. They hate us.

BRUNO: I'm sure they don't hate you.

SCHMUEL: They do, but that's all right because I hate them too. I ***hate*** them!

BRUNO: You don't hate Father, do you? *(Long pause)* Anyway, I have something to tell you too. I'm going back to Berlin. We're leaving on Saturday.

SCHMUEL: But for how long?

BRUNO: I think it's forever. Mother doesn't like it at Out-With *(Bruno's pronunciation of Auschwitz)* – she says it's no place to bring up children – so Father is

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staying here to work because the Fury has big things in mind for him, but the rest of us are going home.

SCHMUEL: So I won't see you again?

BURNO: Well, someday, yes. You could come on a holiday to Berlin. You can't stay here forever after all. Can you?

SCHMUEL: I suppose not. I won't have anyone to talk to anymore when you're gone.

BRUNO: **(Pg 197-199)** I wish we'd got to play together. Just once. Just to remember. We've been talking to each other for more than a year and we never got to play once. All this time I've been watching where you live from my bedroom window and I've never even seen for myself what it's like

SCHMUEL: You wouldn't like it. Yours is much nicer.

BRUNO: I'd still like to have seen it.

SCHMUEL: *(putting his hand under the fence and lifting a little)* Well? Why don't you then?

BRUNO: But if I was caught I'd be in trouble.

SCHMUEL: That's true. I suppose I'll see you tomorrow to say goodbye then.

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BRUNO: Unless . . . . Don't you remember that you said I looked like you? Since I had my head shaved? Well, if that's the case and if I had a pair of striped pyjamas too, then I could come over on a visit and no one would be any the wiser.

SCHMUEL: Would you do it? You could help me look for Papa.

BRUNO: Why not. The only problem is getting a spare pair of striped pyjamas.

SCHMUEL: That's all right. There's a hut where they keep them. I can get some in my size and bring them with me. Then you can change and we can look for Papa.

BRUNO: Wonderful. Then it's a plan!

[The next day, the two boys meet for the last time.]

(Pg 202-203) Schmuel lifted the bottom of the fence off the ground and handed a pair of striped pyjama bottoms, a striped pyjama top and a striped cloth cap exactly like the one he was wearing, underneath to Bruno.

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BRUNO: Well, turn round. I don't want you watching me. *(Schmuel turns and Bruno changes clothes)* When was this last washed?

SCHMUEL: I don't know if it's ever been washed.

(Bruno finishes changing)

BRUNO: **(Pg 204)** There, you can turn back now. *(They wander into the camp)*

If it wasn't for the fact that Bruno was nowhere near as skinny as the boys on [this] side of the fence, and not quite so pale either, it would have been difficult to tell them apart. It was almost as if they were all exactly the same really.

BRUNO: **(Pg 205)** I'm pretending to be a person from the other side of the fence.

SCHMUEL: A Jew, you mean.

BRUNO: Yes, that's right.

(Pg 208) Everywhere [Bruno] looked, all he could see was two different types of people: either happy, laughing, shouting soldiers in their uniforms or unhappy, crying people in their striped pajamas, most of whom

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seemed to be staring into space as if they were actually asleep.

BRUNO: I don't think I like it here.

SCHMUEL: Neither do I.

(Pg 209-210) The two boys spent an hour and a half searching the camp. They weren't sure exactly what they were looking for, but they didn't find anything at all that might give them a clue to Shmuel's papa's disappearance, and it started to get darker.

BRUNO: I'm sorry, Shmuel. I'm sorry we didn't find [anything]. I think I ought to go home now. Will you walk back to the fence with me? *(Actor playing Schmuel steps behind Bruno and whistles loudly – the whistle is the sound of the solders getting ready to order people on a march).* What's happening? What's going on?

SCHMUEL: It happens sometimes. They make people go on marches.

BRUNO: Marches! I can't go on a march. I have to be home in time for dinner. It's roast beef tonight.

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SCHMUEL: Sshhh! Don't say anything or they get angry.

BRUNO: **(Pg 211-213)** Does the marching go on for long?

SCHMUEL: I don't think so. I never see the people after they've gone on a march. But I wouldn't imagine it does.

BRUNO: That's it. I'm going to catch a cold out here. I have to go home.

But as he said this, his feet brought him up a set of steps and into a long room that was surprisingly warm and must have been very securely built because no rain was getting in anywhere. In fact it felt completely airtight.

BRUO: Well, that's something. I expect we'll have to wait here till [the rain] eases off and then I'll get to go home. I'm sorry we didn't find your Papa. [And] I'm sorry we didn't really get to play, but when you come to Berlin, that's what we'll do. You're my best friend, Schmuel. My best friend for life!

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At that moment there was a loud gasp from all the marchers who had filled the room. The door at the front was suddenly closed and a loud metallic sound rang through from the outside.

And then the room went very dark and somehow despite the chaos that followed, Bruno found that he was holding Schmuel's hand in his own and nothing in the world would have persuaded him to let it go.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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